

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Stakeholder Map

Plot the people who shape your quality mandate by influence and interest, then choose a deliberate approach for each.

Purpose

A stakeholder map tells you where to spend your limited political capital. As a QA leader you rarely control the levers you need — budget, engineering time, release decisions — so you influence them through other people. This tool forces you to be honest about who holds power, who cares about quality, and how each relationship currently stands, so your engagement is planned rather than reactive.

The core mechanism is an influence-by-interest grid. "Influence" is how much a person can help or block your agenda. "Interest" is how much they currently care about quality outcomes. The combination tells you the right posture: whom to actively manage, whom to keep satisfied, whom to keep informed, and whom to simply monitor.

When to use it

- In your first weeks in a role, to map the terrain before you commit to a plan.
- Before launching any change that needs cross-team buy-in — a shared quality gate, a testing strategy, a headcount request.
- When an initiative is stalling and you suspect the blocker is a person, not a technical problem.
- Ahead of a reorganisation, a new exec sponsor, or a major release where accountability will be contested.
- Quarterly, as a lightweight review — relationships and priorities drift, and a map more than a quarter old is usually stale.

Instructions

1. List every person who can materially help or block your quality agenda. Include sceptics, not just allies — the people who can block you matter most.
2. Rate each on influence (High / Low) over the outcomes you care about, and on interest (High / Low) in quality itself. Be honest, not aspirational.
3. Place each name in one of the four quadrants below.
4. For each person, capture what they want, what they fear, and how the relationship stands today (supportive / neutral / sceptical).

5. Choose one deliberate approach and a single next action per person. Vague intentions such as "build rapport" do not count — name the meeting, the message, or the data you will bring.
6. Note who influences whom. Often the fastest route to a sceptic is through a peer they already trust.
7. Revisit as relationships move. The goal is to shift key people towards higher interest and stronger support over time.

The four quadrants and the posture each calls for:

Quadrant	Influence / Interest	Approach
Manage closely	High influence, high interest	Engage often, involve in decisions, co-own outcomes. These are your true partners and sponsors.
Keep satisfied	High influence, low interest	Do not overload with detail; give them the headline, the risk and the decision they must make. Lose these and your agenda dies.
Keep informed	Low influence, high interest	Useful allies and information sources. Keep them close; they often become advocates.
Monitor	Low influence, low interest	Light touch. Do not spend scarce capital here until their position changes.

Worked example

Newly appointed QA lead at Northstar Digital, mapping the stakeholders around a proposed shared quality gate and a shift towards earlier QA involvement.

Stakeholder	Quadrant	What they want	What they fear	Stance today
Priya Nadar — VP Engineering	Manage closely	Faster delivery without more production incidents; decisions framed in risk and outcomes.	A QA leader who reports test-case counts and cannot connect quality to delivery.	Supportive but time-poor
The CTO — exec sponsor	Keep satisfied	"Faster, safer releases" and "more automation" — currently undefined.	Being surprised by an incident the board hears about first.	Neutral, high altitude
Tom Fielding — Head of Product	Manage closely	To hit growth dates and ship features.	QA becoming a late, opaque blocker that threatens his roadmap.	Neutral, reasonable when shown residual risk
Marcus Lee — Payments squad lead	Keep satisfied	Autonomy for his engineers; no process he sees as overhead.	QA slowing his squad or implying his developers cannot self-test.	Sceptical — unconvinced, not hostile
Sofia Alvarez — senior QA	Manage closely	Recognition, a real say, stability after last year's failed automation push.	Another top-down change that ignores the team's hard-won knowledge.	Wary ally
Dan Whitmore — automation engineer	Keep informed	His flaky Selenium suite to stop consuming his life; to do work that is valued.	Being left to maintain a suite nobody trusts, alone, indefinitely.	Supportive, quietly burning out

The tailored approach that follows from the map:

Stakeholder	Deliberate approach	Next action
Priya	Treat as primary sponsor. Bring risk-and-outcome framing, never activity metrics. Co-author the quality-gate proposal so it is hers as much as mine.	Fortnightly 30-minute standing slot; first one to agree the two metrics we will move.
CTO	Keep satisfied with a short, quarterly risk-and-trend view. Translate "faster, safer" into a measurable definition and get it acknowledged.	One-page proposal defining "safer release" as change failure rate and escaped defects, routed via Priya.
Tom	Convert from neutral to partner by making QA the thing that protects his dates, not threatens them. Show residual risk plainly so he can decide.	Offer a release risk summary for his next launch; let him experience QA as an informer, not a blocker.
Marcus	Do not push process. Win one concrete result in a domain he cares about (payments risk), then let evidence do the persuading.	Ask to pair on the payments critical-path risks; bring findings, not a mandate.
Sofia	Make her a co-owner of the strategy, explicitly crediting the team's exploratory strength. Address the automation scar directly.	Ask her to co-lead the quality-gate design; name last year's failure and what we will do differently.
Dan	Relieve the burnout signal quickly to build trust, and reframe his role from lone suite-owner to enabler of shared ownership.	Agree a triage plan for the flaky suite; make suite health a shared, visible metric, not his private burden.

What the map reveals: the initiative lives or dies on Priya (sponsor) and Tom (delivery), so they are managed closely. Marcus is high-influence-low-interest — the classic "keep satisfied" who must not be over-managed or lectured. The route to Marcus runs through a payments result and, indirectly, through Priya's backing, not through direct persuasion.

Blank reusable version

Stakeholder	Influence (H/L)	Interest (H/L)	Quadrant	What they want	What they fear	Stance (supportive/neutral/sceptical)

Stakeholder	Deliberate approach	Who influences them	Next action	By when

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Mapping only your allies and ignoring the sceptics who can actually block you. Confusing seniority with influence over your specific agenda. Rating interest as you wish it were rather than as it is. Treating a "keep satisfied" senior stakeholder to a deluge of detail and losing them. Building the map once and never

revisiting it. And the cardinal error: using the map to manipulate rather than to serve people better — colleagues can tell the difference, and trust, once spent, does not come back.

How to interpret / use it well

- The quadrant sets the communication dose, not the person's worth. "Keep satisfied" means concise and decision-focused, not neglected.
- Movement is the point. A good map this quarter shows sceptics edging towards support and low-interest stakeholders warming up — because of specific actions you took.
- Route through trust. When a direct approach to a sceptic is unlikely to land, reach them through a peer they already believe.
- Pair this with the Difficult Conversation Planner for high-stakes individuals and the Executive Quality Update for your "keep satisfied" seniors.
- Keep it private and keep it kind. This is a planning aid for serving stakeholders better, not a scorecard to share.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Influence is earned in the currency each stakeholder values. Priya values risk and delivery outcomes; Marcus values a result in his own domain; Tom values his dates being protected. Learn each person's currency and pay in it — the same message dressed in test-case counts would bankrupt you with all three.